



Collaborate in an Innovative Way

Among all the innovation happening around free software is Cyn.in, an innovative business model that makes open source software a profitable commercial product.

*I*nnovation drives business; innovation creates new businesses—innovation is business. You will find a lot of proprietary companies playing hide and seek and then patting their own backs for their so-called innovations. They also seem to suggest that if you are creating something innovative, you must lock the code in your trunk. But the free software world follows a different philosophy of innovation. We have all heard the saying: “Necessity is the mother of all inventions” – something that the free software world lives by. However, the proprietary corporate world likes to go by the rule, “Innovate and create a need so that you can rule.”

Cyn.in is primarily a collaboration tool and platform that enables businesses to connect their people with each other and share their collective knowledge. The tool makes it easy for employees to work with each other and with key stakeholders outside the company. Users on board the platform can share knowledge, get answers, improve decision-making, and hence work much faster and productively.

“Think of it as a ‘Facebook+Wikipedia for businesses’, that a company of any size can set up within its corporate network. It combines the capabilities of various collaborative social applications like wikis, blogs, file repositories, microblogging, discussions, event calendars and more, into a single seamless platform. Teams use these tools to create, share and discuss knowledge using an intuitive Web interface or a rich desktop client,” says Romasha Roy Choudhury, business director–Cyn.in, Cynapse.

Core features

The core capabilities of Cyn.in are to securely and rapidly store, retrieve, co-author and discuss any form of digital content within virtual work areas called ‘Spaces’. Over these core capabilities, a layer of content applications such as wikis, blogs, bookmarks, image/video/audio galleries, file repositories etc, provide for easy knowledge collaboration between users with diverse needs. “A key differentiator of Cyn.in is that, unlike most collaboration suites available for the enterprise, it is not a set of diverse applications loosely coupled into a suite. On the contrary, more than 85 per cent of Cyn.in’s features are common across the platform,” explains Romasha.

Google recently launched Wave, which the search engine giant claims to reform the way people communicate over the Internet. It seems Cyn.in already does most of it. So, how different would Wave be from Cyn.in? “Yes, we have been quite excited internally about the Google Wave announcement. There is a strong similarity in end goals (i.e., eventually making e-mail obsolete), and also in some levels in the user experience of the two offerings. However, we are solving the problems at different levels. While Cyn.in aims at being a convergence point for all kinds of knowledge collaboration, Wave looks at content communication from a protocol perspective, and focuses on providing a foundation and open standards for the same,” opines Romasha.

“For Wave to be greatly successful, it would need to be adopted and integrated with collaboration platforms such as Cyn.in. The